

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PROVINCIAL & REGIONAL KINGDOMS

Bengal • Gujarat • Malwa • Jaunpur • Kashmir • bounded
Ahom/Assam

Topic-specific deterministic schematic — not to scale where geographic.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Practice workbook method

This premium workbook deliberately begins with routed PYQ demands and then tests every major mechanism: chronology, political geography, state capacity, trade, architecture, source criticism and the bounded Ahom extension. The answer key is not a label-only key. Each explanation identifies the correct reasoning and contrasts it with the nearest plausible alternative. The original broad and remedial key sequences are independently auditable below; routed PYQs are excluded from answer rotation because they are not reconstructed questions.

How to learn from the routed PYQs

A routed PYQ is a verified pointer to an examinable demand, not permission to recreate a question whose original options or official key are unavailable locally. For the 2023 Gujarat-Diu route, make a two-column distinction before seeing options: **Mahmud Begarha = earlier resistance to Portuguese interference; Bahadur Shah = later Bassein-Diu pressure in a context including Humayun**. This isolates the chronology trap. For the dynasty and foundation-period routes, make a grid of ruler/dynasty, region, approximate phase and one discriminator. If the wording or official key is absent, state the limitation rather than upgrading a plausible inference into an "official answer."

Broad-MCQ error log

Error type	Correction habit	Topic 08 example
Right fact, wrong ruler	attach every fact to a ruler and sequence	Begarha's resistance is not Bahadur Shah's later concession
Right place, wrong mechanism	identify what the geography enables	Malwa's plateau means corridor leverage, not a coast
Attractive cultural overclaim	state what the evidence can and cannot prove	architecture shows patronage/craft, not total social harmony
One-cause answer	insert institution and elite coalition	Bengal's ecology needed Ilyas Shahi organisation
Source absolutism	specify source, inference and limit	Buranjis preserve institutional detail but are courtly records

Mains self-marking grid

Before comparing with a model answer, ask whether every paragraph has the full sequence: **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**. A 10-marker normally needs two or three precise examples; a 15-marker needs four or more across dimensions; a 20-marker needs comparison, causation and a reasoned verdict. In this topic, evidence should be a named ruler, site, route or source-not a vague phrase such as "there was cultural synthesis." Mark down an answer that makes a port explain everything, treats a monument as a social census, or drifts into detailed Ahom funerary Art & Culture.

PART II - Solved topic-specific MCQs: routed PYQs and original broad coverage

Routed PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2023 Q49: Gujarat, Portuguese pressure and Diu

PYQ demand (neutral routing): distinguish the Gujarat ruler sequence around Portuguese pressure, Bassein/Diu and the wider context of Humayun.

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Confidence: High. The safe route separates Mahmud Begarha's earlier resistance to Portuguese interference from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu position when Humayun's threat mattered. Eliminate a choice that assigns the later concession to Begarha, reverses the rulers, or treats the decision as a voluntary expression of uncontested Gujarati strength. The repository does not contain the official option set or readable official key, so this is an evidence-based inference, not an official answer.

Routed PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 Q92: king-dynasty pairs

PYQ demand (neutral routing): test king-dynasty-region discipline for early/medieval pairs relevant to the topic's chronology method.

OFFICIAL KEY UNAVAILABLE LOCALLY - ROUTED, NOT RECONSTRUCTED. Do not invent the original options. Solve by making a four-column check-ruler, dynasty, region and sequence-and eliminate a pair that crosses Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur or adjacent regional traditions. Confidence in the method is high; confidence in any unpreserved option answer would be false precision.

Routed PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2023 Q45: medieval dynasties and foundation periods

PYQ demand (neutral routing): distinguish founding-period and region associations for Hoysala, Gahadavala, Kakatiya and Yadava traditions.

OFFICIAL KEY UNAVAILABLE LOCALLY - ROUTED, NOT RECONSTRUCTED. This is an adjacent chronology drill, not a licence to fabricate a solved paper. Use a time-place grid, remove options that transpose Deccan and Ganga-valley contexts, and keep it distinct from Topic 08's Bengal-Gujarat-Malwa-Jaunpur-Kashmir core. Confidence: medium for the local routing, not an official-key claim.

Original broad-coverage MCQs (32; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation)

Q1. Which explanation best accounts for Bengal's ability to retain autonomy after Firuz Tughlaq's campaigns?

A. Distance, difficult land-water communications and climate combined with Ilyas Shahi organisation and the Ekdala strategy. B. A complete absence of trade routes connecting the delta to other regions. C. The permanent deployment of a Lodi governor at Pandua. D. Mandu's plateau fortifications blocking every approach to Bengal.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct: ecology raised the cost of projection, while dynasty and strategy made autonomy durable. B is the closest distractor because difficult conquest did not mean isolation; Chittagong, textiles and Chinese contact show active connectivity.

Q2. Which sequence correctly identifies Ilyas Shah's consolidation?

A. He founded Ahmedabad after annexing Jaunpur in 1484. B. He captured Lakhnauti and Sonargaon in 1342 and ruled as Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah. C. He abolished jizyah in Kashmir after Sikandar Shah. D. He shifted Malwa's capital from Dhar to Mandu.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct and attaches ruler, places and date. A is the closest distractor because it contains real Topic 08 places and a date, but Ahmedabad belongs to Ahmad Shah I and Jaunpur's annexation to Bahlul Lodi.

Q3. What is the most careful use of the Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah justice anecdote?

A. It proves that Bengal had no social hierarchy or legal inequality. B. It is irrelevant because court stories never contain historical information. C. It reveals a courtly ideal of justice and should be read with trade, diplomacy and other evidence rather than as a social census. D. It establishes that Ghiyasuddin was a Gujarat ruler who founded Ahmedabad.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because the anecdote is evidence of a normative legitimacy claim. A is the closest distractor because a justice story can be historically meaningful, but it cannot establish universal legal experience.

Q4. Which feature most securely identifies the mature regional idiom at Gaur and Pandua?

A. Slender stone turrets and ornate brackets derived from Gujarat's Jain craft tradition. B. Massive high-plinth buildings with coloured glazed tiles characteristic of Mandu. C. Lofty gates and huge arches associated with the Sharqi idiom at Jaunpur. D. Brick and mortar, broad sloping arches, curvilinear roofs and locally adapted decorative motifs.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct for Bengal. A is the closest distractor because it is a plausible regional architectural description, but it belongs to Gujarat rather than the brick-rich Bengal setting.

Q5. Which statement best describes Alauddin Hussain Shah's relevance to Bengal?

A. His reign combined a new dynastic phase with Bengali literary patronage, recruitment of Hindus to high office and expansion towards Chittagong-Arakan. B. He was the Sharqi ruler annexed by Bahlul Lodi in 1484. C. He was Mahmud Begarha's successor who captured Girnar and Champaner. D. He founded the Tai-Ahom polity at Charaideo.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct because it connects post-succession consolidation, patronage, incorporation and external policy. B is the closest distractor because both involve eastern regional politics, but Jaunpur's Sharqi kingdom-not Bengal-was annexed by Bahlul.

Q6. Why should Gujarat's 1407 independence be distinguished from Ahmad Shah I's rule?

A. 1407 ended all rivalries with Malwa and Mewar. B. Formal independence under Muzaffar Shah preceded Ahmad Shah's consolidation of nobles, administration and Ahmedabad as a capital. C. Ahmad Shah ruled Bengal before Ilyas Shah. D. The distinction concerns only the shape of Charaideo moidams.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct: proclamation and durable state-building are separate processes. A is the closest distractor because independence did change Gujarat's political status, but Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry remained central.

Q7. Which combination best captures Mahmud Begarha's statecraft?

A. He relied on Bengal's Kosi boundary and never intervened in Saurashtra. B. He confined Gujarat to Patan and abandoned all commercial routes. C. He pursued Girnar and Champaner, made route security a concern through inns and caravanserais, and faced Portuguese interference in trade. D. He was a Kashmir ruler who restored temples and abolished jizyah.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it joins strategic conquest, route security and maritime pressure. A is the closest distractor because boundaries matter in the topic, but the Kosi belongs to the Bengal-Delhi settlement.

Q8. Which statement correctly separates the two Gujarati Portuguese episodes?

A. Bahadur Shah, not Begarha, founded Ahmedabad in 1413. B. Mahmud Begarha made the Bassein concession while facing Ilyas Shah. C. The Portuguese affected only inland Malwa and never Gujarat's coast. D. Mahmud Begarha is linked to earlier resistance; Bahadur Shah's later Bassein-Diu position must be read with pressure from Humayun.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because it preserves chronology and multi-directional pressure. B is the closest distractor because it recognises a Portuguese connection, but it wrongly assigns Bahadur Shah's later constrained position to Begarha.

Q9. Why was Malwa a strategic hinge?

A. Its plateau commanded routes between Gujarat, north India and the north-south corridor, making it relevant to Gujarat, Mewar, Bahmanis and Lodis. B. It controlled the only route from China to Chittagong. C. It was an isolated coast with no connection to Rajasthan. D. Its importance rested exclusively on poetic patronage at Jaunpur.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct because route command explains Malwa's repeated political salience. D is the closest distractor because cultural patronage mattered in regional states, but Jaunpur's learned reputation cannot explain Malwa's geography.

Q10. Which evidence best illustrates Hushang Shah's relationship with commercial groups?

A. He made Ma Huan the chief minister of Bengal. B. He patronised Jains, important merchants and bankers; Nardeva Soni appears as treasurer and adviser. C. He ordered the Lodi annexation of Jaunpur in 1484. D. He instituted Paik rotation in the Brahmaputra valley.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct and offers a named link between court and commercial personnel. A is the closest distractor because Ma Huan is connected to a trade source, but he was a Chinese interpreter-account writer, not Hushang's minister.

Q11. What is the safest interpretation of Mahmud Khalji's temple destruction in conflicts with Mewar and neighbouring rulers?

A. It proves that every Malwa ruler followed one unchanging policy. B. It can be ignored because military evidence never matters. C. It must be condemned and placed in its wartime context; particular campaigns do not by themselves establish a general policy across all Malwa rule. D. It establishes that Malwa was permanently subject to Gujarat.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it neither erases violence nor overgeneralises from it. A is the closest distractor because Mahmud Khalji is politically important, but Hushang Shah's different policies show variation within Malwa.

Q12. Which event best demonstrates how Malwa's internal contest altered the wider balance?

A. The Kosi treaty between Firuz and Ilyas Shah. B. Alauddin Hussain Shah's patronage of Bengali writers. C. Zainul Abidin's restoration of Kashmir's libraries. D. Mahmud II's conflict with Medini Rai drew in Rana Sanga and Gujarat, while the Lodis watched Chanderi and Malwa.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because a factional dispute in Malwa connected to Mewar, Gujarat and Lodi interests. A is the closest distractor because it is also a boundary settlement, but it belongs to Bengal's earlier relationship with Delhi.

Q13. Why are the Sharqis called the Sharqis?

A. Their founder Malik Sarwar held the title Malik-us-Sharq, lord of the east. B. They governed Saurashtra from the fort of Girnar. C. They were the first Tai-Ahom chroniclers at Charaideo. D. They founded the Ilyas Shahi line at Pandua.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct and explains a dynastic label through a political title. D is the closest distractor because both are eastern regional dynasties, but the Ilyas Shahi line belongs to Bengal.

Q14. Which description of Jaunpur is most accurate?

A. A small coastal settlement dependent upon Portuguese customs. B. A Ganga-valley Sharqi kingdom with territorial reach, a distinctive idiom of lofty gates and arches, and a learned reputation as the Shiraz of the East. C. A plateau capital of Malwa built around glazed tiles. D. A Kashmir valley court ruled by Zainul Abidin.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct because it joins territorial, architectural and cultural dimensions. C is the closest distractor because it gives a real regional architectural description, but it belongs to Mandu in Malwa.

Q15. What does Bahlul Lodi's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur show?

A. Bengal's delta had become directly governed by Delhi. B. All regional cultural traditions vanished with a single battle. C. The earlier balance was changing as the Lodis extended control in the Ganga valley; Sharqi cultural memory could outlast sovereignty. D. The Portuguese had conquered Ahmedabad.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it states both a political break and cultural continuity. B is the closest distractor because annexation was decisive for sovereignty, but it did not erase Jaunpur's architectural and learned traditions.

Q16. Which contrast is correct for Kashmir?

A. Sikandar and Zainul Abidin followed identical policies toward temples, jizyah and returning non-Muslims. B. Zainul Abidin ruled before the 1320 Mongol attack. C. The Rishi tradition proves that coercion was impossible in Kashmir. D. Sikandar Shah's coercive phase should be distinguished from Zainul Abidin's reversals, restorations and broader reconciliation.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because the contrast between reigns is the historical point. A is the closest distractor because both rulers belong to Kashmir, but their policies are specifically presented as different.

Q17. Which named evidence best supports an argument that Zainul Abidin linked legitimacy with social and economic reconstruction?

A. Restoration of grants and temples, return of non-Muslims, high office for Hindus, translation patronage and encouragement of crafts and agriculture. B. The Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort. C. Girnar, Champaner and Portuguese resistance. D. Malik Sarwar's title Malik-us-Sharq.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct because it connects reconciliation to institutions, learning and material activity. C is the closest distractor because it gives a coherent state-building cluster, but it belongs to Gujarat.

Q18. What can regional architecture securely establish?

A. That a court's subjects enjoyed equal status regardless of class or community. B. That rulers patronised particular materials, crafts, labour and urban forms, which can be related to political geography when cross-checked. C. That every building was made only by the ruler's own religious community. D. That a single monument fixes the exact boundary of a kingdom.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct because material culture can show patronage and technique. A is the closest distractor because architecture can be socially meaningful, but it is not a census of equality.

Q19. Which is the strongest evidence ladder for Bengal's external connection?

A. One architectural photograph without date or context. B. A later courtly title alone. C. Chinese diplomatic contact, Ma Huan's perspective, Chittagong, textiles and re-export, interpreted with the limit of each source. D. An assertion that delta states cannot participate in oceanic trade.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it triangulates diplomacy, trade nodes and an observer while retaining a limit. B is the closest distractor because courtly titles can indicate legitimacy, but they cannot alone demonstrate commercial connection.

Q20. Which statement best defines the fifteenth-century balance of power?

A. A formal federation with a written constitution binding Gujarat, Malwa, Mewar, Bengal and Jaunpur. B. A world in which states never intervened beyond their capitals. C. A single Delhi army controlling every regional court. D. A recurring pattern of checks among regional powers, shaped by rivalry, alliances and contested corridors rather than fixed modern borders.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because it treats balance as a pattern of interaction. A is the closest distractor because the states were interconnected, but there was no federation or fixed constitutional equality.

Q21. What is the appropriate place of the Ahom case in this topic?

A. A bounded comparison showing Brahmaputra-valley state formation beyond the Delhi-centred provincial system. B. A substitute for studying Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and Kashmir. C. A detailed survey of every funerary architectural form at Charaideo. D. Evidence that Paik service operated under the Sharqis.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct because it broadens comparison without displacing the core cases. C is the closest distractor because Charaideo is relevant, but detailed funerary form is deliberately routed to Art & Culture.

Q22. Which statement most accurately describes Paik organisation for this bounded extension?

A. A coin used for north Indian land revenue accounts. B. A rotational service arrangement linking adult male subjects or households to labour and military mobilisation. C. A title held by the Gujarat governor of Saurashtra. D. A Bengali brick architectural feature.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct and avoids reducing an institutional obligation to a vague labour label. A is the closest distractor because fiscal vocabulary matters in state history, but Paik is a service organisation, not coinage.

Q23. How should Buranjis be used?

A. As neutral transcripts that need no contextual reading. B. Only as decorative evidence for moidam art. C. As royal chronicles useful for sequence and institutional detail, read with awareness of court perspective and silences. D. As proof that Assam was an administrative division of the Lodis.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it states both utility and limitation. A is the closest distractor because chronicles can be rich evidence, but their royal viewpoint prevents treating them as neutral transcripts.

Q24. Which topic boundary is methodologically correct?

A. Use no Charaideo evidence in History because UNESCO is only Art & Culture. B. Explain the full ritual cosmology of every moidam before discussing Ahom state formation. C. Treat World Heritage listing as proof of a political treaty with Delhi. D. Use Charaideo, Paik and Buranjis here for polity, chronology and sources; route detailed funerary form, cosmology and conservation to Art & Culture.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because it preserves an examinable anchor while preventing scope drift. B is the closest distractor because ritual form is genuinely important, but it exceeds this History module's stated boundary.

Q25. Which chronology is safest for Gujarat?

A. Muzaffar Shah -> Ahmad Shah I -> Mahmud Begarha -> Bahadur Shah. B. Mahmud Begarha -> Ilyas Shah -> Zainul Abidin -> Bahlul Lodi. C. Ahmad Shah I -> Malik Sarwar -> Sikandar Shah -> Siu-kha-pha. D. Bahadur Shah -> Muzaffar Shah -> Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah -> Hushang Shah.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct for the Gujarat sequence used in this package. D is the closest distractor because several names are medieval rulers, but it mixes regions and reverses Gujarat's order.

Q26. Which example most directly shows that state capacity involved more than conquest?

A. A claim that only one battlefield determines a state's history. B. Ahmad Shah's control over nobles and administration, urban development at Ahmedabad, and Begarha's concern with safe roads and caravanserais. C. A monument interpreted without its capital, patron or material context. D. A chronological list with no explanation of mechanisms.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct because it names administrative, urban and route-security dimensions. A is the closest distractor because conquest mattered, but durable capacity also required institutions and protected movement.

Q27. Which statement best applies source criticism to a monument?

A. A monument has no historical value because it is not a written text. B. A monument proves the private beliefs of every person in the kingdom. C. A monument can demonstrate patronage, craft and material adaptation; combine it with texts and context before making a claim about society or policy. D. A monument removes the need to identify its date, place or patron.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it identifies both inference and limit. B is the closest distractor because monuments can have broad cultural significance, but they cannot reveal every subject's private belief.

Q28. Which comparative thesis is strongest?

A. All regional kingdoms followed the identical Delhi administrative model. B. Bengal's autonomy was caused only by rain, Gujarat's only by ports, and Malwa's only by a fort. C. Regional culture was politically irrelevant because states fought wars. D. Regional courts shared the task of converting local resources into authority, but Bengal's delta, Gujarat's commercial network, Malwa's plateau and Ahom service organisation did so by different mechanisms.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because it gives a shared frame without flattening cases. B is the closest distractor because it recognises distinct environments, but its single-cause wording erases institutions and elite coalitions.

Q29. Which inference about Bengal is defensible?

A. Its delta location made external conquest costly while waterways, trade and court organisation connected rather than isolated the region. B. Its climate alone automatically created an independent dynasty. C. Its Chinese contact proves that no local languages were patronised. D. Its brick architecture proves that all religious conflict was absent.

Answer: A Explanation: A is correct because it combines constraint, connectivity and organisation. B is the closest distractor because climate mattered, but environmental conditions did not automatically create the Ilyas Shahi state.

Q30. What is the safest answer route for a Diu-related objective question?

A. Treat every Gujarat ruler as interchangeable because all were connected to the coast. B. Check ruler sequence first: Begarha's resistance is distinct from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu context, then test the role of Humayun's pressure. C. Assume a detailed treaty clause without the original question or official key. D. Move the episode to Chittagong because both are ports.

Answer: B Explanation: B is correct because it uses chronology and multi-causal context. A is the closest distractor because coastal connection is relevant, but it is precisely the ruler confusion the question is designed to test.

Q31. Which pairing is correctly matched?

A. Mandu - brick curvilinear roofs and Chittagong re-export. B. Jaunpur - Jain-derived slender turrets and Ahmedabad's Jama Masjid. C. Gujarat - fine stonework, brackets and turrets; Bengal - brick and locally adapted roof vocabulary. D. Kashmir - Kosi boundary and Ekdala fort.

Answer: C Explanation: C is correct because it distinguishes Gujarat's stone-craft idiom from Bengal's brick adaptation. B is the closest distractor because both are regional architectural styles, but Jaunpur is associated with lofty gates and huge arches.

Q32. What is the most useful forward linkage from Topic 08?

A. Regionalisation ended all negotiations after 1484. B. Babur entered a political vacuum because no regional court retained resources or memory. C. Only the Ahom extension matters for later imperial history. D. Lodi expansion, the Malwa-Mewar-Gujarat contest and durable regional courts form the setting in which Mughal expansion had to negotiate, defeat or incorporate existing powers.

Answer: D Explanation: D is correct because it turns regionalisation into a transition to later empire-building. B is the closest distractor because Delhi's weakness mattered, but the evidence in this topic shows active regional states rather than a vacuum.

Remedial trap MCQs (12; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation)

R1. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Bengal.

A. Firuz's campaigns made Bengal permanently subordinate to Delhi after the Kosi settlement. B. Ilyas exchanged gifts with Firuz, but the source says he was not subordinate. C. Ekdala helped make direct conquest and retention difficult. D. Bengal's waterways could support both defensive mobility and commercial connection.

Answer: A Explanation: A is inaccurate: gift exchange and a boundary settlement did not make Bengal subordinate. B is the closest distractor because it too concerns Firuz-Ilyas relations, but it states the source's explicit qualification.

R2. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Kashmir.

A. Sikandar Shah's reign must be distinguished from Zainul Abidin's. B. Zainul Abidin simply continued Sikandar Shah's coercive orders without reversal or restoration. C. Zainul's measures included restored grants and temples, abolition of jizyah and high office for Hindus. D. A single reign should not be projected across all medieval India.

Answer: B Explanation: B is inaccurate because Zainul Abidin cancelled earlier orders and pursued reconciliatory measures. A is the closest distractor because it makes precisely the chronological distinction required to avoid the trap.

R3. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about terms and regions.

A. Fanam is associated with south Indian/coastal gold circulation rather than a standard Delhi Sultanate office. B. Paik concerns rotational service and mobilisation in the Ahom context. C. Fanam was the standard Delhi Sultanate office through which Sharqi governors collected Bengal's Kosi tribute. D. Buranjis are Ahom royal chronicles that need source criticism.

Answer: C Explanation: C is inaccurate because it turns a coin term into a fabricated Delhi office and mixes unrelated regions. A is the closest distractor because it correctly names fanam's broad south/coastal association without inventing a Delhi function.

R4. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about architecture.

A. Bengal's brick forms can show local material adaptation and patronage. B. Gujarat's fine stonework can be linked to Jain/Gujarati craft traditions. C. Mandu's high plinths and glazed tiles belong in a discussion of capital-scale patronage. D. A regional monument proves complete social integration and equality across the kingdom.

Answer: D Explanation: D is inaccurate because a monument is not a social census. B is the closest distractor because it makes a focused, supportable inference from craft tradition rather than an absolute claim about society.

R5. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Gujarat and the Portuguese.

A. Mahmud Begarha made Bahadur Shah's later Bassein-Diu concession while under Humayun's pressure. B. Mahmud Begarha is associated with earlier resistance to Portuguese interference in Gujarat's trade. C. Bahadur Shah's later position should be read with both maritime and inland pressure. D. A safe answer avoids inventing exact treaty clauses when the source record is unavailable.

Answer: A Explanation: A is inaccurate because it collapses two rulers and two contexts. B is the closest distractor because it gives the correct earlier Begarha association, which is exactly why the later Bahadur episode must be kept separate.

R6. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Paik organisation.

A. Paik service can be analysed as a means of labour and military mobilisation. B. Paik was simply chattel slavery and has no institutional or rotational dimension. C. The arrangement should be described as an obligation whose form changed over time rather than with a loose label. D. The Ahom example broadens comparison beyond a Delhi-centred map.

Answer: B Explanation: B is inaccurate because it erases rotational service and institutional context. A is the closest distractor because it identifies the mobilisation function without falsely equating the system to chattel slavery.

R7. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about the Ahom boundary.

A. Charaideo can anchor a History discussion of royal memory, chronology and sources. B. Buranjis can be used for institutions while noting a courtly perspective. C. This History module must fully explain moidam funerary form, cosmology, World Heritage criteria and conservation management. D. Detailed funerary architecture is deliberately routed to Art & Culture.

Answer: C Explanation: C is inaccurate because it breaches the declared disciplinary boundary. D is the closest distractor because it states the proper route for the detailed Art & Culture material.

R8. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Jaunpur.

A. The Sharqi kingdom had a Ganga-valley territorial setting. B. Its court patronised learning and came to be called the Shiraz of the East. C. Its distinctive style used lofty gates and huge arches. D. Jaunpur was a delta port whose main political resource was Chittagong's maritime trade.

Answer: D Explanation: D is inaccurate because it transposes Bengal's delta-port context onto Jaunpur. B is the closest distractor because it states Jaunpur's real cultural resource without denying its territorial political role.

R9. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Gujarat's strength.

A. Gujarat was powerful only because it possessed ports; its hinterland, crafts, Ahmedabad and route security were irrelevant. B. Fertile land and handicrafts supplied the productive base linked to ports. C. Ahmedabad concentrated a court, markets and building patronage. D. Safe roads and caravanserais help explain why a court cared about commercial movement.

Answer: A Explanation: A is inaccurate because it reduces a commercial state to a shoreline. B is the closest distractor because it names the productive hinterland that a port-only explanation leaves out.

R10. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about fifteenth-century conflict.

A. Gujarat, Malwa and Mewar competed through corridors, border states and factional alliances. B. Fifteenth-century conflict was simply and uniformly Hindu versus Muslim, making geography and dynastic rivalry irrelevant. C. Hushang Shah, Mahmud Khalji and Rana Kumbha show that local political choices require contextual reading. D. A source-critical answer can acknowledge violence without making an essentialist civilisational claim.

Answer: B Explanation: B is inaccurate because it erases strategic and dynastic mechanisms that structure the evidence. A is the closest distractor because it supplies the actual regional logic of the western contest.

R11. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about Buranjis.

A. They may preserve sequence, court decisions and institutional vocabulary. B. Their royal setting requires attention to perspective and silence. C. They are neutral transcripts that can be used without asking whose viewpoint they privilege. D. They are useful in a bounded Ahom comparison, not proof that Assam was a Lodi province.

Answer: C Explanation: C is inaccurate because royal chronicles are not viewpoint-free. B is the closest distractor because it states the correct critical caution while retaining the source's usefulness.

R12. Identify the inaccurate or unsafe statement about transition.

A. Bahlul's annexation of Jaunpur altered the eastern balance. B. Lodi, Mewar, Gujarat and Malwa contests form part of the setting before Babur. C. Regional political memories and capacities could outlast formal annexation. D. Regionalisation made later Lodi and Mughal negotiation, conquest and incorporation unnecessary.

Answer: D Explanation: D is inaccurate because later empire-building confronted active regional powers and rivalries. B is the closest distractor because it correctly identifies the competitive setting inherited by Babur.

Original solved Mains practice

Question M1. Analyse why the fifteenth century should be understood as regional state formation rather than merely the decline of the Delhi Sultanate. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Delhi's contraction redistributed sovereignty; it did not create an institutional vacuum. Regional courts made authority durable by connecting local geography, elites and resources.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's 1338 break and Ilyas Shah's 1342 capture of Lakhnauti and Sonargaon show a delta court using costly communications and Ekdala-style defence to resist Delhi. Gujarat's 1407 formal break was followed by Ahmad Shah I's control of nobles, Ahmedabad and an urban-commercial base. Malwa's Mandu plateau commanded trunk routes, while Sharqi Jaunpur combined Ganga-valley administration with learned prestige. These are positive capacities, not residual fragments.

Qualification and verdict. The system remained contested: Gujarat-Malwa-Mewar rivalry, Malwa factionalism and Bahlul's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur show that autonomy was neither uniform nor permanent. Yet the evidence supports a plural regional state-system, not a simple narrative of collapse.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses four named cases, explains mechanisms and qualifies durability.

Question M2. Examine architecture and literary patronage as instruments of regional legitimacy. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Regional courts used buildings and patronage to make sovereignty visible in local idioms and to attract cultural networks.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's Gaur-Pandua idiom used brick, broad sloping arches and curvilinear roofs; patronage of Maladhar Basu and later Bengali writers linked courtly authority with local language. Ahmad Shah I's Ahmedabad drew on Jain/Gujarati stone craft-brackets, carving and turrets-while concentrating bazaars, mosques and madrasas. Sharqi Jaunpur's lofty gates, huge arches and "Shiraz of the East" reputation converted scholarship and saintly networks into political prestige. Mandu's high plinths and glazed tiles marked a strategically placed capital.

Qualification and verdict. Buildings prove patronage, material and craft traditions, not complete social integration. Read with political geography and texts, they show culture functioning as statecraft rather than decorative excess.

Why this earns marks: It gives four named examples, turns form into analysis and states a source limit.

Question M3. Discuss how geography and political economy shaped the capacities of Bengal, Gujarat and Malwa. (15 marks, 200 words)

Model solution

Claim. Geography mattered through routes, revenue, logistics and institutions; it was not an automatic cause of political success.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's distance, humid climate and difficult land-water communications raised the cost of Delhi's campaigns. Ilyas Shah and Ekdala converted that constraint into autonomy, while waterways, textiles and Chittagong linked the delta to Chinese and wider maritime exchange. Gujarat combined fertile land, handicrafts, Ahmedabad and west-coast ports. Ahmad Shah I's capital and Mahmud Begarha's caravanserais, safe roads and campaigns in Saurashtra show a court protecting the commercial chain from interior production to sea trade. Malwa's plateau between the Narmada and Tapti commanded north-west-south corridors; Mandu therefore mattered to Gujarat, Mewar, Bahmanis and Lodis.

Qualification and verdict. Bengal was not isolated, Gujarat was not powerful through ports alone, and Malwa's strategic position also intensified factional and external conflict. The comparison shows three different routes to capacity-riverine, commercial and corridor-based-within one regional state-system.

Why this earns marks: It compares rather than lists, supplies six named evidence points and rejects environmental determinism.

Question M4. "The balance of power in fifteenth-century north India was both stabilising and fragile." Discuss. (15 marks, 200 words)

Model solution

Claim. Regional checks prevented easy concentration of power, yet the same rivalries and internal factions made the system unstable and open to reorganisation.

Named evidence -> analysis. Gujarat, Malwa and Mewar checked one another because Malwa's corridors and Rajasthan's border states mattered to all three. Muzaffar Shah's treatment of Hushang Shah, later intervention through rival factions, and Rana Kumbha's rise show that influence could be pursued without stable frontier change. In the east, Bengal was checked by Orissa and Jaunpur; the Sharqis maintained a large Ganga-valley kingdom and constrained Bengal's advance. Bahlul Lodi's 1484 annexation of Jaunpur then changed this balance. In Malwa, Mahmud II's conflict with Medini Rai drew in Rana Sanga and Gujarat; Lodi concern over Chanderi shows how a local succession conflict became a north Indian issue.

Qualification and verdict. "Balance" was not a formal alliance system or a peaceful equilibrium. It was a recurring pattern of constraint, whose fragility lay in changing elite coalitions and expanding rivals. This is why the Lodi-Mughal transition must be read against active regional politics.

Why this earns marks: The answer defines the term, demonstrates both sides with named events and reaches a qualified judgement.

Question M5. Assess the place of trade in the strength and vulnerability of Bengal and Gujarat. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Trade multiplied state capacity when courts connected production, transport, towns and security; it also made valuable routes vulnerable to coercion and competition.

Named evidence -> analysis. Bengal's waterways were an internal transport system as well as a defensive environment. Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah's Chinese contact, Chittagong's growth, ocean-going ships, fine textiles and re-export of Chinese goods show a delta court participating in external circuits. Alauddin Hussain Shah's push towards Chittagong and Arakan further shows that control of a port could be politically valuable. Yet this does not make trade independent of power: court organisation, urban centres and agrarian production sustained the circuit.

Gujarat's fertile land and handicrafts supplied a different commercial chain. Ahmad Shah I's Ahmedabad concentrated markets and craft, while its ports carried much of north India's sea trade. Mahmud Begarha's effort to secure roads, build caravanserais and act against piracy demonstrates the institutional side of commerce. Portuguese interference in West Asian trade exposed the coast's value; Begarha's unsuccessful anti-Portuguese effort must be separated from Bahadur Shah's later constrained Bassein-Diu position under pressure that included Humayun.

Qualification and verdict. Neither port data nor court claims license invented trade volumes or an assumption that all producers prospered equally. Trade was embedded in labour, credit, protection and political strategy. It made both Bengal and Gujarat resilient regional powers, while creating prized nodes through which outside pressure could operate.

Why this earns marks: It gives a two-way assessment, uses named evidence across both cases, preserves the Diu chronology and avoids unsupported data.

Question M6. Compare the Delhi-centred regional state-system with the bounded Ahom/Assam extension. How should Buranjis and Charaideo be used? (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. The Ahom case broadens the study of state formation without turning Assam into a delayed province of Delhi or replacing the Bengal-Gujarat-Malwa-Jaunpur-Kashmir comparison.

Named evidence -> analysis. In the north Indian system, Bengal's Ilyas Shahi court drew capacity from delta mobility and trade; Gujarat from hinterland, Ahmedabad and ports; Malwa from plateau corridors; Jaunpur from Ganga-valley reach and cultural capital; Kashmir from a distinctive valley polity. The Tai-Ahom entered the Brahmaputra valley under Siu-kha-pha in the thirteenth century, and Charaideo became the first capital and royal necropolis. Paik rotation connected households or adult male subjects to labour and military mobilisation, illustrating a service-based capacity that cannot be reduced to port wealth or Delhi's provincial administration.

Buranjis are royal chronicles: they can supply sequence, institutional vocabulary and court decisions, but their perspective requires cross-questioning. UNESCO's live property page verifies 90 royal moidams at Charaideo from the thirteenth to nineteenth centuries. In this answer, that is evidence for royal memory, chronology and the relevance of Buranjis.

Qualification and verdict. Do not call Paik chattel slavery, or use World Heritage status as a substitute for historical analysis. Detailed moidam form, cosmology and conservation belong to Art & Culture. Within this boundary, the Ahom case demonstrates plural political ecology and improves, rather than dilutes, the regional-state thesis.

Why this earns marks: It maintains the scope boundary, compares mechanisms, treats sources critically and ends with a precise verdict.